friendship with the Soviet Union, which, from India's point of view, would be a more trustworthy ally than Western nations.

During the 1962 War, Ayub Khan had protested vehemently against American and British military aid to India, arguing that it would 'enlarge and prolong the conflict', and that the weapons would be used against Pakistan over the Kashmir dispute.[30] And the West could not afford to antagonize Pakistan, a member of the pro-Western Southeast Asia Treaty Organisation (SEATO) as well as the Central Treaty Organisation (CENTO).[31]

Pakistan was in the curious position of being a member of two Western-organized defence pacts while remaining a close ally of China. And India's alliance with the Soviet Union would inevitably accelerate the country's progression along the serious collision course it was already on with China. It is clear that India's decision makers felt the country needed a strong and decisive prime minister who could lead them through the extremely tangled situation in which the region was embroiled during these turbulent years. Furthermore, the choice of Indira Gandhi would ensure continuity. She was Nehru's daughter and, although not a relative, she had the same surname as the Mahatma.

In China, meanwhile, Mao Zedong was rapidly consolidating his grip on power. The 1959 Lushan Conference that had led to the purge of some of Mao's most prominent rivals and enemies was followed by intrigues and manoeuvrings which lasted well into 1962. If Mao was depressed in the beginning of 1962, as his physician Li Zhisui wrote in his book about the Chairman, it was not until a conference at the seaside resort town of Beidaihe in August of that year that 'the banner of militant Marxism-Leninism', in the words of Roderick MacFarquhar, could once again be 'unfurled over Beijing'.[32] Mao blamed the disastrous consequences of his Great Leap Forward on Liu Shaoqi, Zhou Enlai, Deng Xiaoping, Chen Yun, and other so-called 'moderates' within the party. 'We (meaning himself) had been talking about making agriculture the foundation, but this had not actually been practised by his [Mao's] colleagues…in the four years from 1959 to 1962.'[33]

MacFarquhar points out that the last time a dispute over economic policy had been transmuted into political struggle was at the 1959 Lushan Conference, 'as Mao reminded them, and then it had resulted in the purge